



The Verdict

IN THE WORLD'S largest democracy, politics and elections are always in the spotlight. But 2024 will see more than half-a-dozen states going to polls as well as the big General Elections, where the incumbent *Narendra Modi* government will battle to retain its majority. New political alliances may be forged and new promises made to voters. In the first six months of 2024, Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh and Sikkim will go to the polls, while in the latter half, assembly elections will be held in Maharashtra, Haryana and Jharkhand.

COMETH THE HOUR

UNION FINANCE MINISTER *Nirmala Sitharaman* is a person for all seasons. She will present the NDA government's Interim Budget ahead of the 2024 elections, and the question doing the rounds is: Will she maintain fiscal discipline while making room for poll promises? She has said that it will be a simple Vote on Account. But pre-poll Budgets can often be populist and speculation is rife that she will make at least one grand announcement on February 1.



RATE RELIEF?

IN THE PAST two years, the US Federal Reserve has hiked its benchmark rate 11 times in an effort to curb inflation. The Reserve Bank of India has followed a similar trajectory. Central bankers around the world are possibly heaving a sigh of relief as inflation shows signs of cooling down. This positive trend has raised the possibility of interest rates softening in 2024. But, history has shown that it might not be so simple. Unforeseen events have upset well-laid plans to control inflation many times since the pandemic started receding. Hence, central bankers need to remain vigilant.

REST & RELAXATION

Travel and tourism firms are raring to jump on to the bandwagon of new travel trends in 2024, particularly event-based travel. "It is emerging as a significant trend, driven by the enthusiasm of India's millennials, young professionals and GenZers. Their interest in live concerts, events and cultural immersion is poised to be a driving force," says Rajeev Kale, President and Country Head of Thomas Cook India. With young Indians embracing relaxed vacations, destinations like Goa and Coorg, among others, are expected to gain traction.

